

Road Trip Essentials Guide

Purpose

This guide provides essential information for preparing a vehicle, understanding basic Indian traffic regulations, and following best practices for safe and enjoyable road trips. It is intended for travelers using motorcycles, cars, or bicycles and serves as a quick reference before and during travel.

1. Pre-Trip Planning Checklist

Before starting any journey, verify the following:

Travel Planning

- Confirm destination and route.
- Check weather forecast.
- Estimate fuel requirements.
- Reserve accommodation if required.
- Download offline maps.
- Inform a trusted person about your itinerary.

Personal Preparation

- Carry valid identification.
- Keep emergency contacts accessible.
- Charge mobile phone and power bank.
- Pack sufficient drinking water and snacks.
- Carry required medications.

2. Motorcycle Readiness Checklist

Perform the following inspection before every long ride.

Engine

- Check engine oil level.
- Inspect for oil leaks.
- Verify coolant level (liquid-cooled motorcycles).

Tyres

- Check tyre pressure.
- Inspect tread depth.
- Look for cuts or punctures.

Brakes

- Test front and rear brakes.
- Check brake fluid level.
- Listen for unusual noises.

Chain & Transmission

- Clean and lubricate the chain.
- Check chain tension.
- Inspect sprockets.

Electrical System

- Headlight
- Tail light
- Brake light
- Indicators
- Horn

Fuel

- Fill fuel tank.
- Identify nearby fuel stations for remote routes.

Documents

- Driving License
- Registration Certificate (RC)
- Insurance
- Pollution Under Control (PUC) Certificate (where applicable)

3. Car Readiness Checklist

Engine

- Engine oil
- Coolant
- Brake fluid
- Windshield washer fluid

Tyres

- Tyre pressure
- Spare tyre condition
- Wheel alignment

Battery

- Battery terminals
- Battery charge

Safety Equipment

- Spare tyre
- Jack
- Wheel spanner
- Tow rope
- Jumper cables
- Reflective warning triangle

Lights

- Headlights
- Brake lights
- Fog lights
- Indicators

Documents

- Driving License
- Registration Certificate
- Insurance
- PUC Certificate (where applicable)

4. Bicycle Readiness Checklist

Before long-distance cycling, inspect:

- Tyre pressure
- Brakes
- Chain lubrication
- Gear shifting
- Lights
- Bell
- Water bottle
- Repair kit
- Spare tube
- Mini pump

5. Essential Vehicle Toolkit

Recommended items:

- Multi-tool
- Screwdriver set
- Adjustable wrench
- Tyre inflator
- Puncture repair kit
- Flashlight
- Zip ties
- Duct tape
- Gloves

6. Basic Indian Traffic Rules

Driving Side

Vehicles drive on the **left-hand side** of the road.

Helmet Rules

- Helmets are mandatory for motorcycle riders and pillion passengers in most states.
- ISI-certified helmets are recommended.

Seat Belt Rules

- Seat belts should be worn by both front-seat occupants.
- Rear-seat seat belts should also be used where available.

Mobile Phone Usage

Using a handheld mobile phone while driving or riding is prohibited.

Use hands-free systems only when safe.

Drinking and Driving

Driving under the influence of alcohol or drugs is illegal and dangerous.

Always designate a sober driver.

Speed Limits (General Guidance)

Urban Roads

30–50 km/h

State Highways

60–80 km/h

National Highways

80–100 km/h

Expressways

100–120 km/h

Note: Always follow posted speed limit signs, as limits vary by road and state.

7. Required Documents

Travelers should carry:

- Driving License
- Vehicle Registration Certificate
- Insurance Certificate
- Pollution Under Control (PUC) Certificate (where applicable)
- Government-issued ID

Digital copies stored in DigiLocker may be accepted where legally permitted.

8. Toll Roads & FASTag

FASTag enables electronic toll collection on most National Highways.

Recommendations:

- Ensure FASTag has sufficient balance.
- Recharge before long journeys.
- Keep a backup payment method.

9. Fuel Planning

Recommendations:

- Refuel before entering remote regions.
- Avoid letting fuel drop below one-quarter tank.
- Locate fuel stations along the planned route.
- Carry additional fuel only where legally permitted and using approved containers.

10. Best Practices for Road Trips

Route Planning

- Plan rest stops.
- Avoid unknown shortcuts.
- Keep an alternate route available.

Driving

- Maintain safe following distance.
- Avoid sudden lane changes.
- Drive defensively.
- Follow traffic signals.

Breaks

Take a 15–20 minute break every 2–3 hours.

Fatigue significantly increases accident risk.

Night Driving

- Reduce speed.
- Use low beam when appropriate.
- Avoid isolated roads when possible.
- Stay alert for animals and pedestrians.

Mountain Roads

- Use lower gears on descents.
- Avoid overtaking on blind curves.
- Honk before sharp bends.
- Drive slowly.

Monsoon Travel

- Increase braking distance.
- Avoid waterlogged roads.
- Drive smoothly.
- Use headlights during poor visibility.

Summer Travel

- Stay hydrated.
- Monitor engine temperature.
- Carry extra drinking water.

11. Eco-Friendly Travel

Travel responsibly by:

- Avoiding littering.
- Carrying reusable water bottles.
- Respecting wildlife.
- Staying on designated roads and trails.

- Supporting local businesses.

12. Vehicle Breakdown Guide

If your vehicle breaks down:

1. Move to a safe location.
2. Turn on hazard lights.
3. Place a reflective warning triangle behind the vehicle.
4. Contact roadside assistance.
5. Stay away from moving traffic.

13. Minor Accident Procedure

If involved in a minor accident:

- Stay calm.
- Check for injuries.
- Move vehicles only if safe.
- Exchange contact and insurance information.
- Document the scene with photographs.

14. Emergency Checklist

Always carry:

- Water
- First Aid Kit
- Flashlight
- Phone Charger
- Power Bank
- Basic Toolkit
- Emergency Contacts
- Snacks

15. Quick Reference Checklists

Before Leaving Home

- ✓ Route planned
- ✓ Weather checked
- ✓ Fuel filled

- ✓ Vehicle inspected
- ✓ Documents packed
- ✓ Emergency contacts informed

Before Starting the Engine

- ✓ Tyres checked
- ✓ Lights working
- ✓ Mirrors adjusted
- ✓ Seat belt or helmet secured
- ✓ Navigation ready

Before Entering Mountain Roads

- ✓ Fuel tank sufficiently filled
- ✓ Brakes tested
- ✓ Lower gears understood
- ✓ Weather conditions reviewed

16. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Should I inspect my vehicle before every road trip?

Yes. A basic inspection helps reduce the risk of breakdowns and improves safety.

Q: Is FASTag mandatory?

FASTag is widely used for electronic toll collection on National Highways and helps avoid delays at toll plazas.

Q: How often should I stop during long drives?

Take a break every 2–3 hours or whenever you feel fatigued.

Q: Is it safe to drive at night?

Night driving requires additional caution due to reduced visibility and driver fatigue. Avoid it when possible on unfamiliar or remote roads.

Q: What should I do if my vehicle overheats?

Stop in a safe location, switch off the engine, allow it to cool naturally, and check the coolant level only after the engine has cooled.